

Sustainable Urban Transportation
Fall Quarter 2026
Final Group Project Rubric
C. Scott Smith, Instructor

Group Project (Paper @ 10 points; Presentation @ 10 points; 20 points total)

Students will work in groups of three or four to complete a paper and presentation that will be handed in and presented at the end of the quarter. The scope and methods of the project will be defined largely by group members under the supervision of the instructor but also enriched by occasional evaluations by peer groups. The overall approach should be either analytical or prescriptive in its design.

The subject matter of the project should address a socially relevant transportation issue in the city of Chicago aimed at advancing the three dimensions of sustainability: economic, environmental, or social.

Part 1: Paper (10 points)

The final paper should contain approximately 1,500 words of text (about 6 double-spaced pages), formatted in 12-point Times New Roman with 0.5-inch margins. The aim of your proposal should be clearly stated in the title. Include the following sections:

- **Introduction:** Clearly state your topic and objectives.
- **Background (Literature Review):** Summarize and synthesize existing research, plans, or policies that define your issue. Explain how the issue compromises sustainable transportation and discuss its economic, environmental, and social dimensions.
- **Methods / Proposal:** Describe the framework you used to either better understand or rectify the problem. Adapt the approach to a particular setting or context so that it has value for the broader Chicago metropolitan area transportation community.
- **Discussion and Conclusion:** Interpret your findings, propose recommendations, and highlight implications for policy or practice.
- **Bibliography:** Include at least five professional or scholarly sources (past research, plans, policies, reports, data, etc.) formatted in the Chicago Manual of Style.

In addition, include *at least two original figures* (maps, system diagrams, design concepts, or other visuals) that effectively communicate complex information relevant to your topic.

Part 2: Presentation (10 points)

Groups will present their work during finals week via a ten-minute presentation: approximately 7 minutes of presentation followed by 3 minutes for feedback, questions, and answers. The presentation should mirror the structure of the paper (introduction, background, methods or proposal, discussion and recommendations) and close with a bibliography slide. Aim for roughly 10–12 slides.

The presentation should include several (five or more) original figures that support essential aspects of your study. Figures from the paper may be reused, and you are encouraged to use your creative energy when producing additional ones. All group members are expected to contribute and present content they assisted in creating.

Recommendations

- Use a reference management application such as Zotero (free) or EndNote to ease formatting of the bibliography and in-text citations.

- Strategically select and coordinate article reviews and field exercises so that they collectively inform the final project.
- Use a cloud-based group authoring program (with headings) to manage and streamline workflow.

Citation Examples (Chicago Manual of Style)

- **Book:** Townsend, Anthony M. *Smart Cities: Big Data, Civic Hackers, and the Quest for a New Utopia*. New York: W. W. Norton & Company, 2013.
- **Journal Article:** Litman, Todd. "Evaluating Transportation Equity: Guidance for Incorporating Distributional Impacts in Transportation Planning." *Journal of Transport Geography* 12, no. 1 (2019): 1–9.
- **Report:** City of Chicago Department of Transportation. *Strategic Plan for Transportation: 2021–2026*. Chicago: CDOT, 2021.
- **Website:** Metropolitan Planning Council. "Equitable Transit-Oriented Development." Accessed October 17, 2025. <https://www.metroplanning.org/>.

Evaluation Rubric

Part 1: Paper (10 points)

Criteria	Excellent (A)	Proficient (B–C)	Needs Improvement (D–F)
Topic and Focus (1 point)	Clearly defined, relevant, and well-structured topic addressing a critical sustainability issue in Chicago; aim is stated in the title. 1 pt	Topic is adequate but may lack precision or clear linkage to sustainability or the Chicago context. 0.5 pt	Topic is vague, unfocused, or unrelated to sustainability. 0 pts
Background / Literature Review (2 points)	Comprehensive synthesis of at least five scholarly and professional sources; clearly explains how the issue compromises the economic, environmental, and social dimensions of sustainability. 2 pts	Some relevant sources but limited synthesis; one or more dimensions of sustainability are underdeveloped. 1–1.5 pts	Insufficient sources or weak understanding of context; dimensions of sustainability not addressed. 0–0.5 pts
Methods / Proposal (3 points)	Innovative, rigorous, and contextually grounded framework or solution with clear value to the Chicago transportation community. 3 pts	Sound but somewhat generic or underdeveloped approach; connection to the Chicago context is limited. 2–2.5 pts	Unclear, incomplete, or inappropriate methodology. 0–1.5 pts
Figures and Visuals (1 point)	At least two clear, original figures (maps, system diagrams, design concepts, etc.) that enhance understanding and are referenced in the text. 1 pt	Figures included but limited in originality, clarity, or relevance. 0.5 pt	Few or no meaningful figures. 0 pts
Discussion and Conclusions (2 points)	Insightful interpretation and recommendations with strong implications for policy or practice. 2 pts	Some interpretation or recommendations but lacking depth or clarity. 1–1.5 pts	Minimal discussion or unsupported conclusions. 0–0.5 pts
Writing Quality, Formatting, and Citations (1 point)	Well-organized, clearly written, approximately 1,500 words, and properly formatted; in-text citations and bibliography follow Chicago style. 1 pt	Readable but contains organizational, length, formatting, or citation inconsistencies. 0.5 pt	Poorly written, well outside the length requirement, or improperly formatted and cited. 0 pts
Paper Subtotal			10 points

Part 2: Presentation (10 points)

Criteria	Excellent (A)	Proficient (B–C)	Needs Improvement (D–F)
Content and Organization (3 points)	Presentation clearly covers introduction, background, methods/proposal, discussion, and recommendations in a logical sequence; key findings from the paper are distilled effectively; includes a bibliography slide. 3 pts	Most sections are present but the flow is uneven, some content is superficial, or the slides repeat the paper without synthesis. 2–2.5 pts	Major sections missing, disorganized, or content is unclear. 0–1.5 pts
Visual Design and Original Figures (3 points)	Slides are clean and readable; five or more original figures (maps, designs, system diagrams, flow charts) communicate complex information in a meaningful and creative way. 3 pts	Slides are generally readable but text-heavy or inconsistent; fewer than five original figures, or figures have limited originality or relevance. 2–2.5 pts	Slides are cluttered or hard to read; few or no original figures. 0–1.5 pts
Delivery and Timing (2 points)	Presenters speak clearly and confidently, engage the audience, and deliver content within the allotted 7 minutes. 2 pts	Delivery is understandable but relies heavily on reading slides, or the presentation runs noticeably over or under time. 1–1.5 pts	Delivery is difficult to follow or the presentation significantly exceeds or falls short of the time limit. 0–0.5 pts
Group Participation (1 point)	All group members contribute and present content they helped create; transitions between speakers are smooth. 1 pt	All members present, but contributions are noticeably uneven. 0.5 pt	One or more members do not participate. 0 pts
Response to Questions and Feedback (1 point)	Group answers questions accurately and thoughtfully, drawing on their research during the 3-minute Q&A. 1 pt	Responses are partially accurate or somewhat vague. 0.5 pt	Group is unable to answer questions or responses are inaccurate. 0 pts
Presentation Subtotal			10 points

Score Summary

Component	Points Possible	Points Earned
Part 1: Paper	10	
Part 2: Presentation	10	
Total	20	